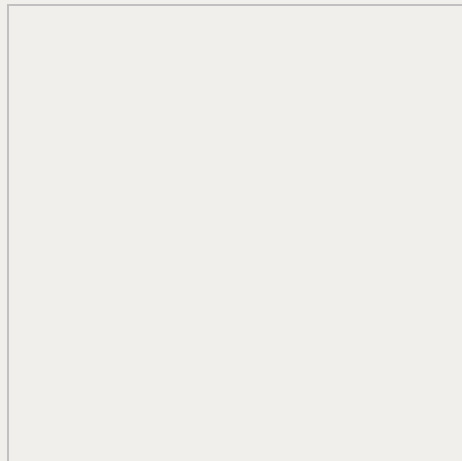


IN CONTEXT

The women's court

In 1607, Caccini began work at the Medici women's court, which according to the scholar Suzanne G. Cusick, was "widely acknowledged as the de facto seat of Medicean power." Here, Caccini created music for the elite of Tuscany, under Grand Duchess Christina of Lorraine (co-regent with Maria Maddalena of Austria), a major promoter of the arts. Aside from her composing, Caccini had perfected the complex breathing techniques that produced a form of singing that symbolized Medicean power and was seen as a product and endorsement of its authority. A hugely respected figure, with access to the region's most powerful people, she was able to help implement her female patron's cultural and political agendas.



MEDAL SHOWING THE HEAD OF
CHRISTINA OF LORRAINE

Francesca Caccini was born into a musical family in Florence in